E-Course Policy

Superior University

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E-Course Development & Review Policy for Open and Distance Learning (ODL) Mode

1. Introduction

This policy outlines the requirements, procedures, and best practices for developing and reviewing e-courses for the Open and Distance Learning (ODL) mode. The goal is to ensure that all courses are designed to meet high standards of quality, accessibility, and effectiveness, providing a consistent and engaging learning experience for students.

2. Course Development Process

2.1 Course Overview and Introduction

- **Clear Instructions**: Ensure that instructions are clear on how students can get started and navigate through the course. The location of course components should be easily accessible.
- **Course Purpose & Structure**: Introduce the learners to the purpose and structure of the course, providing a clear understanding of what to expect.
- **Communication Expectations**: Clearly state communication expectations for online discussions, emails, and other forms of interaction.
- **Institutional Policies**: Include or link to course and institutional policies that learners must comply with.
- **Technology Requirements**: Clearly state the minimum technology requirements for the course, and provide information on how to obtain these technologies.
- **Skill Requirements**: Clearly state the computer and digital information literacy skills expected of the learner.
- **Prerequisite Knowledge**: Clearly state any expectations for prerequisite knowledge or required competencies.
- **Instructor Introduction**: The instructor must provide a professional self-introduction, available online.
- **Learner Introductions:** Include activities that ask learners to introduce themselves to the class.
- **Welcome Content:** Provide welcome and getting started content through a Course Information area that includes the syllabus, available in a printable PDF format.
- **Course Orientation:** Provide an orientation or overview to guide students on how to navigate the course and understand task deadlines.
- **Homepage Design:**The course homepage should visually represent the course, include a brief course description or introduction, and provide clear instructions for students, with navigation to current content accessible within three clicks.
- **Navigation:** Hide any items not used from Course Navigation to reduce clutter.
- **Learning Objectives:** Provide learning objectives, grading policies, late work policies, communication guidelines, and contact information on the homepage.

- **Participation Expectations**: Clearly communicate participation expectations, technology requirements, and any supplemental materials required.
- **Resource Access**: Ensure that the course provides access to campus and HEC resources, such as technical help, orientation, and tutoring.

2.2 Learning Objectives (Competencies)

- **Measurable Outcomes**: Clearly describe the course learning objectives or competencies, ensuring they are measurable.
- **Module-Level Objectives**: Ensure that module or unit-level learning objectives are measurable and align with course-level objectives.
- **Clarity and Location**: Learning objectives or competencies should be clearly stated, written from the learner's perspective, and prominently located within the course.
- **Alignment with Activities**: Clearly state the relationship between learning objectives or competencies and learning activities.
- **Appropriate Level**: Ensure that learning objectives or competencies are appropriate to the level of the course.

2.3 Instructional Materials

- **Alignment with Objectives**: Ensure that instructional materials contribute to achieving the stated learning objectives or competencies.
- **Explanation of Use**: Clearly explain the relationship between instructional materials and learning activities.
- **Academic Integrity**: Model academic integrity by providing source references and permissions for the use of instructional materials.
- **Current Content**: Ensure that instructional materials represent up-to-date theory and practice in the discipline.
- **Variety of Materials**: Use a variety of instructional materials to enhance learning.

3. Course Content Development

3.1 Copyright and Permissions

- **Adherence to Copyright Law:** Follow copyright laws, ensuring no copyright considerations are violated.
- **Permissions:**Ensure permissions (Creative Commons, Copyrights, Fair Use, Public Domain, etc.) are in place and that the HEI follows the same.
- **Funding for Materials:**Allocate appropriate funds for the purchase or development of electronic study materials.
- **Learning Object Repository:** Ensure that every course has a complete instructional material package available in the central Learning Object Repository, with all links, files, videos, and external URLs active and working.

- **Credit Hour Requirements**: Design course content and activities to meet the credit hour requirements delineated in the ODL policy for each delivery mode.
- **Content Organization**: "Chunk" content into manageable pieces using modules organized by units, chapters, topics, or weeks.
- **Text Headers and Indention**: Include text headers and indention within modules to guide student navigation.
- **Module Naming Conventions**: Apply thoughtful naming conventions to modules and items within modules.
- **Module Structure**: Begin modules with an Introduction/Overview page and end with a Conclusion/Summary page to "bookend" each module.
- **External Tools**: Embed external tools within modules or on a page, assignment, discussion, or quiz.
- **Interactive Content**: Ensure lessons include interaction between students, teachers, and content through discussions, feedback, and engaging content.
- **Welcome Discussion**: Include a "Welcome" or "Let's Get Acquainted" discussion.
- **Inline Preview**: Use auto-open inline preview thoughtfully for content.
- **Personalized Learning**: Incorporate personalized learning through module completion requirements or prerequisites.
- **Differentiation:** Include differentiation, such as different due dates, where applicable.
- **Engaging Resources:** Offer access to a variety of engaging resources that facilitate communication, collaboration, content delivery, and student engagement.
- **Critical Thinking:** Provide activities to develop critical thinking and problem-solving skills, aligning with NQF levels for the relevant qualification.
- **Content Characteristics:** Ensure course content is interactive, self-explanatory, inclusive, visual, contextualized, progressive, flexible, and practical.
- **Real-World Applications:** Include activities that emulate real-world applications of the discipline, such as experiential learning, case studies, and problem-based activities.
- **Open Courseware:** Develop Open Courseware and Small Learning Objects as per ODL policy requirements, including explanations, activities, self-assessment questions, further reading, and reference materials.
- **Open Educational Resources:** Use Open Educational Resources, free or low-cost materials where available.
- **Periodic Review:** Implement a policy for the periodic review (at least every 3 years) of course content, materials, and activities to ensure alignment with societal demands and learning outcomes.

4. Course Design and Layout

4.1 Consistency and Navigation

- **Logical Layout**: Establish a logical, consistent, and uncluttered layout that facilitates ease of navigation.
- **Content Organization**: Organize related content together with self-evident titles.
- **Chunking of Information**: Break large blocks of information into manageable sections with ample white space.
- **Contrast and Readability**: Ensure sufficient contrast between text and background for ease of viewing.
- **Instructions**: Provide clear, well-written instructions throughout the course.
- **Error-Free Content**: Ensure the course is free from grammatical and spelling errors.
- **Avoid Flashing Text**: Avoid using flashing or blinking text.
- **Slide Design**: Use predefined slide layouts with unique titles and clear transitions.

5. Accessibility and Usability

5.1 Accessibility Compliance

- **Accommodation Statement**: Include an easily located accommodation statement on the homepage or course overview.
- **Color Usage**: Ensure color does not overpower course information and is not used in isolation to convey meaning.
- **Image Descriptions**: Accompany images with text descriptions (Alt text) or captions for complex descriptions.
- **Text Formatting**: Use styles (e.g., Paragraph, Heading) to format text, with a preference for sans serif fonts like Arial or Helvetica.
- **Controlled Access**: Limit course accessibility to concerned faculty, registered students, the head of the academic department, and LMS administrators.
- **Hyperlink Text**: Ensure hyperlink text incorporates the destination/purpose, avoiding raw URLs, and providing context for screen readers.
- **Multimedia Accessibility**: Accompany audio materials with transcripts and videos/screen casts with closed captions.
- **Table Usage**: Use tables only for tabular data.

5.2 Usability Enhancements

- **Course Navigation**: Design course navigation to facilitate ease of use.
- **Readable Design**: Ensure the course design facilitates readability.
- **Accessible Text and Images**: Provide accessible text and images in all course materials to meet the needs of diverse learners.
- **Vendor Statements:** Provide vendor accessibility statements for all required technologies.

- **Multimedia Accessibility:** Offer alternative means of access to multimedia content to accommodate diverse learner needs.

6. Learning Activities and Interaction

6.1 Activity Design

- **Aligned Activities**: Design learning activities that promote the achievement of stated learning objectives or competencies.
- **Interactive Opportunities**: Provide opportunities for interaction that support active learning.
- **Instructor Interaction Plan**: Clearly state the instructor's plan for interacting with learners during the course.
- **Interaction Requirements**: Clearly communicate the requirements for learner interaction.

7. Course Technology

7.1 Technology Usage

- **Supportive Tools**: Ensure the tools used in the course support learning objectives or competencies.
- **Engagement**: Use course tools that promote learner engagement and active learning.
- **Variety of Technology**: Incorporate a variety of technologies into the course.
- **Data Protection**: Provide learners with information on protecting their data and privacy.

8. Learner Support

8.1 Support Services

- **Technical Support**: Provide clear instructions or links to technical support services.
- **Accessibility Policies**: Articulate or link to the institution's accessibility policies and services.
- **Academic Support**: Provide information or links to the institution's academic support services and resources.
- **Student Services**: Include links to the institution's student services and resources that can help learners succeed.

9. Assessment and Feedback

9.1 Examination Conduct

- **HEC Compliance**: Ensure the examination process complies with the policies, rules, and regulations issued by the HEC.
- **Assessment Policy**: Develop a rigorous process for creating and moderating question papers, assignments, and exams, ensuring that they are conducted by qualified teachers.
- **Assessment Types**: Incorporate both formative (Assignments/Quizzes/GDB) and summative (mid and end semester exams) evaluations.
- **Practical Work**: Conduct and evaluate practical work (if any) through traditional face-to-face modes, ensuring completion before semester exams.
- **Examination Centers**: Establish examination centers within HEIs or other approved institutions, complying with statutory body requirements.

9.2 Assessment Design

- **Objective Measurement**: Ensure assessments measure the achievement of stated learning objectives or competencies across all learning domains (cognitive, affective, psychomotor).
- **Grading Policy**: Clearly state the course grading policy at the beginning of the course.
- **Evaluation Criteria**: Provide specific and descriptive criteria for evaluating learners' work and explain how it connects to the grading policy.
- **Variety of Assessments**: Use a variety of assessments (e.g., discussions, assignments, quizzes) suited to the course level.
- **Feedback Opportunities**: Provide learners with multiple opportunities to track their progress with timely feedback.
- **Sample Assignments**: Include sample assignments to illustrate instructor expectations.
- **Rubrics**: Use rubrics to evaluate assignments and/or discussions.
- **Mastery Tracking**: Enable a Learning Mastery Grade-book for visual representation of outcome mastery.
- **Self-Assessment**: Provide opportunities for students to review their performance and assess their own learning through pre-tests, self-tests, or elective assignments.
- **Timed Responses**: Inform students when a timed response is required, providing adequate lead time.
- **Grade Book Access**: Ensure students have easy access to a well-designed and up-to-date grade book.
- **Feedback Mechanisms**: Provide students with multiple opportunities to give feedback on course design, content, experience, and technology.

10. Review and Continuous Improvement

- **Periodic Review**: Conduct a comprehensive review of course contents, materials, and activities at least every 3 years to ensure alignment with societal demands and learning outcomes.
- **Continuous Refinement**: Update assessment materials and make necessary adjustments every semester to ensure relevance and effectiveness.

Conclusion

This policy serves as a comprehensive guide for the development and review of e-courses in the ODL mode, ensuring that all courses meet the highest standards of quality, accessibility, and effectiveness. By following these guidelines, the institution will provide a consistent, engaging, and supportive learning experience for all students.

Automation and Policy Control Department

The Automation and Policy Control Department at Superior University Lahore plays a critical role in managing and optimizing institutional processes by focusing on two major projects: ERP (Enterprise Resource Planning) and ODL (Open and Distance Learning). Through the implementation of ERP, the department streamlines administrative, academic, and financial operations, ensuring efficient resource management and data-driven decision-making. Simultaneously, the department supports the ODL initiative, enabling flexible and accessible education for a diverse student body through the integration of technology-enhanced learning platforms and robust policy frameworks. This dual focus ensures that Superior University remains at the forefront of innovation in both administrative efficiency and educational accessibility.

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